GeForce 8600GT with 256 MB of integrated DDR3 memory, the G1S ripped through all our game benchmarks. As 136-odd frames in *Doom 3* testify, this laptop can be used for gaming at reasonably high resolutions on most of the current crop of games.

The DV9223tx features the next-best graphics card—a Go version of NVIDIA's GeForce 7600 with 512 MB of video memory. Although not in the G1S' league, this is the second-fastest gaming solution from among all the categories. Both the VX1 and the GS1 feature blazing processors, though none of the other three could be termed *slow*. The only AMD solution was on the TX1016au, a Turion X2 TL 60 that will handle all the processing you can throw at it without breaking into the proverbial sweat. An integrated graphics solution of the GeForce Go 6150 cadre ensure this is no slouch in the multimedia department either. The DV9223tx manages to conceal a whopping 320 GB of storage space in its admittedly large shell.

The ASUS S6F lags behind even the TX1016au, but who's noticing anything behind all that leather anyway? Even though the TX1016au lags behind the group, it's not what you could term a slowcoach. Unless you plan on serious gaming, the TX1016au should pull through most applications.

## The Conclusion

There were two very serious inter-brand rivalries throughout our tests as ASUS and HP fight it out, with neither willing to give ground to the other, and any victories won were extremely hard-fought! At the top, the G1S goes the distance with the DV9223tx. What it gains in performance, it loses on features. They end up within 0.5 points of each other. The second battle takes place a couple of rungs lower as the VX1 takes on the TX1016au—these two boys also finish within a point of each other.

The little S6F loses out on performance points, but is nonetheless a powerful mobile platform in a tiny shell.

After some debate, we decided that since it was such a closely-fought contest, there should be two Gold awards, and no Silver. The ASUS G1S (Rs 99,000) and the HP DV9223tx (Rs 89,990) both win the Digit Best Buy Gold award.

If you want something fashionable that is guaranteed to get drool out wherever you go, the TX1016au is something you should seriously look at. Not only is it brilliantly-priced for a dual-core laptop with 2 GB of memory, you get a host of nifty add-on functions—biometric security, a touchscreen and a tablet form factor (swivel), and a backlit array of touch buttons for media playback.

The ASUS Lamborghini is for those who aspire towards the car but fall short by a million-odd dollars. It's costly, but then you get to flaunt the badge at a tiny fraction of the price. It's fast, too, and extremely functional. We'd have loved to indulge in this sinful fantasy, but at Rs 1,77,000 (the yellow version costs a shade under Rs 2,00,000), even organ-donating won't make up the deficit...


**HP DV9223tx**
Full-fledged entertainment

**Contact Sheet — Laptops**

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| ACI | ACI Technologies | 022-40607000 | sales@aci-asia.com |
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| Compaq | Hewlett-Packard India | 1800-425 66 99/0124-2838700 | tapoti-t.tipnis@hp.com |
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| Lenovo | Lenovo India Pvt Ltd | 080-22108490 | buy@in.lenovo.com |
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| Sony | Sony India Pvt Ltd | 66006600 / 1800-11 11 88 | sonyindia.care@ap.sony.com |
| Zenith | Zenith Computers Limited | 022-28377300 Ext 377 | sgulvady@zenith-india.com |

## Closing Thoughts

Notebook computers have taken strong steps towards becoming adequate processing powerhouses. While they still aren't in the Desktop league and perhaps will never be—as the yardstick for Desktop performance also keeps increasing—they can easily compete on processing power, be it CPU or GPU, with the best Desktops of three years ago. They've become customisable too, with vendors offering a choice of components.

Intel's current Core 2 Duo based platform, the Santa Rosa, has brought with it a host of new, powerful features—as well as price cuts throughout Intel's older chipset line-up, namely the Napa and Sonoma platforms. Intel has chosen to go the platform way, offering the Centrino as a three-part solution consisting of the processor, the chipset, and the wireless solution. AMD chooses a different path by offering just the processor, and leaving it up to the vendor to choose the chipset and other components. With the current range of Core 2 and Core processors, it seems Intel's platforms are suddenly formidable, and if sales figures are any indication, Intel has been steadily encroaching on AMD's notebook market share ever since the Core 2 Duo. Santa Rosa offers a staggering number of features, which includes wireless 802.11n support, Vista-supporting display adapters, and an 800 MHz bus with low power states. (Santa Rosa is also known as Centrino Pro.)

Further on the horizon lurks Montevina, scheduled for a 2008 second quarter release, and support for the upcoming Penryn range of processors with power consumption figures in the range of 29 W on the 45nm fabrication process.

AMD has been cooking up the successor to their Kite and Kite Refresh platforms in the form of their upcoming Turion platform, which will feature more energy-efficient Turion X2 processors, possibly on a smaller fabrication. Support for the emerging 802.11n, HyperFlash, and Hybrid Hard Drive support, along with support for faster memory, is also on the cards. AMD's Fusion processors are also expected in 2009, and this should also cause a chipset overhaul.

With Vista and its heavy Aero interface already being bundled with most notebook computers these days, and the ever-increasing army of resource-hungry applications emerging, we'll soon need every bit of processing juice manufacturers can muster. ⊠

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